



GIRDHARI LAL SARANGI

## Flights of Fancy

As ministers hop on to choppers, the government coughs up a pile

- **NAVEEN PATNAIK, CM**  
No. of Trips: **63**  
Total Cost: **Rs 38, 32,500**
- **PADMANABHA BEHERA,**  
Former mines minister  
No. of Trips: **04**  
Total Cost: **Rs 7, 91,062**
- **P C GHADAI, Finance Minister**  
No. of Trips: **09**  
Total Cost: **Rs 2, 10,6686**
- **BISWABHUSAN HARICHANDAN,**  
Rural Development Minister  
No. of Trips: **32**  
Total Cost: **Rs 81, 35,490**
- **PRAMILA MALLICK,**  
Women & Child Development  
No. of Trips: **02**  
Total Cost: **Rs 2, 21,430**
- **G.B. NAYAK, Fisheries**  
No. of Trips: **02**  
Total Cost: **Rs 1, 60,436**
- **S.N. NAYAK, Agriculture**  
No. of Trips: **05**  
Total Cost: **Rs 11, 60,765**
- **S.N. PATRO, Energy Minister**  
No. of Trips: **10**  
Total Cost: **Rs 12, 00,092**
- **RAGHUNATH MOHANTY,**  
Panchayati Raj Minister  
No. of Trips: **03**  
Total Cost: **Rs 4, 69,118**
- **MANMOHAN SAMAL,**  
Revenue & Food Minister  
No. of Trips: **14**  
Total Cost: **Rs 46, 86,934**
- **A.U. SINGH DEO,**  
Housing & Works Minister  
No. of Trips: **02**  
Total Cost: **Rs 6, 42,127**
- **K.V. SINGH DEO,**  
Urban Development Minister  
No. of Trips: **07**  
Total Cost: **Rs 7, 44,938**
- **DEBASHISH NAYAK,**  
Former information minister  
No. of Trips: **08**  
Total Cost: **Rs 9, 79,700**
- **DEBI PRASAD MISHRA ,**  
Excise & Tourism Minister  
No. of Trips: **03**  
Total Cost: **Rs 5, 44,604**

ters alone spent about Rs 2.50 crore. Besides, a number of bureaucrats also flew to different places for review meetings or aerial surveys spending huge sums of taxpayers' money. Most of the time helicopters were hired from private firms like Deccan Aviation Ltd, MESCO Airlines Ltd and even from IMFA, a company owned by Baijayant Panda, Rajya Sabha MP and a close confidant of Patnaik. Sometimes, the chief minister and his officials travelled to Delhi by chartered aircraft, each trip costing close to Rs 6 lakh even though regular airline flights operate on the route.

These details of Patnaik's Cabinet that is airborne half the time were ob-

tained by Biswajit Mohanty, a social activist who took the Right to Information route to seek details of the flying visits of ministers and bureaucrats. "Air-conditioned vehicles are at the disposal of ministers. Then why this luxury?" Mohanty asks.

What surprised this activist was the official admission that "there are no such rules, guidelines or circulars regarding tours of ministers by chartered aircraft or helicopters". However, the GA Department, under direct charge of the chief minister, informed Mohanty in writing that "aircraft or helicopters of different firms are hired whenever required for undertaking tours of ministers".